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Digital Tools | Workshop

Offices are increasingly digitising their paper documents. OCR software is the tool that enables this process, and the MFD makes it convenient

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MFDs combine a printer, scanner, and in many cases a fax machine. The printer-scanner combo gives an MFD the added functionality of a copier.

Laser MFDs are faster than their inkjet counterparts. Their cost of operation is also lower and so, even though they are priced considerably higher, they are preferred by the small and medium business segment.

Offices are increasingly digitising their paper documents. OCR (Optical Character Recognition) software is the tool that enables this process, and the MFD makes it convenient. OCR software, in conjunction with the scanner, recognises characters in the scanned image of the hard copy and converts it to a document format that a word processor can recognise. This document can then be edited if necessary.

It is sometimes necessary to convert the document to PDF, because this file format is platform-independent and does not require any fonts to be installed—a PDF looks the same on any computer that can read the format. PDF is therefore ideal for exchange and distribution of electronic documents. We shall see how to create a DOC file as well as a PDF from a hard

copy using an MFD.

The OCR software we'll be using is SimpleOCR—because it's free! SimpleOCR has many of the features of paid software—a 1,20,000-word dictionary, error correction, format and image retention, plain text extraction, batch and zone OCR, and more. It is a 9.3 MB download, available from www.charactell.com/scanstore/InstSocr.exe.

To convert a scanned document to PDF, you need a PDF converter. You can use CutePDF Writer, formerly known as CutePDF Printer. CutePDF Writer installs itself as a printer subsystem and can be used to output a PDF file as easily as printing to a printer. This way, any Windows application that can print will be able to output PDF files. CutePDF, too, is free, and is available from www.cutepdf.com/download/CuteWriter.exe. In addition to this, you may also want to install CutePDF Writer Companion, available from www.cutepdf.com/download/CuteComp.exe. This requires a PS-to-PDF converter such as GhostScript, available from www.cutepdf.com/download/converter.exe.

How To Go About It

1. Install all the above software. Place your document on the flatbed glass of the MFD. Launch SimpleOCR.

2. You will be prompted to



The SimpleOCR welcome screen

choose the type of document you want to read. The options are Machine Print and Hand Writing. When you choose Machine Print recognition, you can only scan and OCR documents that are printed, whereas when you choose Hand Writing recognition, you can even scan and OCR handwritten documents—the precision of a



Choose the type of document to scan

different and more powerful OCR engine is used in this case. While the Machine Print recognition engine is free, the Hand Writing recognition engine can be evaluated for 14 days (it costs \$60, or Rs 2,700). Choose the type of document and proceed.

3. In the next screen, you can choose the language. SimpleOCR recognises four languages, including US English and UK English. Choose between these and click Select.

4. You need to select the appropriate scanner for the software to use. Click on File, then on Select Scanner. A window will appear where you can see the list of scanners on your

Using A Laser MFD You Can...

- ☐ Send faxes directly from your computer's modem without having to print the document and feed it manually into the fax machine.
- ☐ Scan photos and e-mail them directly by just pressing a button (on models that support the scan-to-email feature).
- ☐ Use a second function while another function is being performed; this depends on the MFD model.
- ☐ Scan multiple documents in batch-processing mode, and also OCR them.
- ☐ Save received faxes on your computer and print only the required ones.
- ☐ Use it as a copier without the need to connect to a PC by just pressing the Copy button.

And,

- ☐ (Automatic fax/phone switch) If you have a single line for phone calls and faxing, some MFDs will switch to the fax function when there's an incoming fax.

Many ways to power your digital office.



Aficio 2051/
2060/2075
51/60/75 ppm



Aficio 3224C/ 3232C
24/32 ppm
Cost efficient colour,
with B/W
multi-functionality.



Aficio 240W
9 ppm/A7 printing
Super compact
A0 size 3-in 1

PRINT+COPY+FAX+SCAN

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